WORD ORDER TYPOLOGY

Language & Linguistics — classroom PPT

What is word order?

Word order = the conventional ordering of major grammatical constituents in a clause.

For basic word-order typology, the most commonly compared constituents are Subject (S), Object (O), and Verb (V).

Example: English 'The dog chased the cat' → S–V–O.

Typologists normally ask for the dominant/basic order in a neutral declarative transitive clause with lexical (noun) subject and object.

Word order is only one dimension of grammar: case marking, agreement, discourse structure and prosody can also affect constituent placement.



Subject, Verb and Object: what do S, V and O mean?

SUBJECT (S)

The grammatical/argument-like participant conventionally associated with the subject position.

In simple transitive examples it is often the more agent-like participant.

Example: 'The boy kicked the ball.' → The boy = S.

VERB (V)

The verbal predicate that expresses an action, event, process or state.

Example: 'The boy kicked the ball.' → kicked = V.

For typology, V is the central predicate around which S and O are ordered.

OBJECT (O)

The transitive participant conventionally associated with object position.

In simple transitive examples it is often the more patient-like participant.

Example: 'The boy kicked the ball.' → the ball = O.

Important: WALS 81A uses S and O in a semantically informed way (A = more agent-like argument; P = more patient-like argument) because 'subject' and 'object' are not equally straightforward in every language.

Why study word order typology?

Reveals how languages vary and what patterns recur across unrelated languages.

Helps distinguish language-specific rules from cross-linguistic tendencies.

Shows that word order correlates with other grammatical patterns such as adpositions, genitives, adjectives and relative clauses.

Provides evidence for linguistic universals: statements about what is common, rare or systematically correlated across languages.

Helps reconstruct historical change: a language may shift from one dominant order to another while retaining older structural traits.

Provides a bridge between syntax, semantics, discourse/information structure and language change.

Greenberg's contribution: a short historical note

Joseph H. Greenberg's chapter 'Some Universals of Grammar with Particular Reference to the Order of Meaningful Elements' appeared in Universals of Language (1963).

His original comparative sample contained 30 languages from several regions and language families.

He examined several structural dimensions together: dominant S–O–V order, prepositions/postpositions, and adjective–noun order, among others.

The original sample found three common dominant orders: SOV, SVO and VSO; the other three logically possible orders were absent or extremely rare in that sample.

Greenberg formulated 45 universals, many of them statistical/correlational rather than absolute rules.

His major contribution was not simply listing word orders, but identifying correlations among apparently independent grammatical features.

Greenberg's six logically possible orders

SOV

Subject–Object–Verb
Japanese, Hindi, Turkish

SVO

Subject–Verb–Object
English, Mandarin, French

VSO

Verb–Subject–Object
Irish, Welsh, Modern Standard Arabic

VOS

Verb–Object–Subject
Nias, Malagasy (often classified VOS)

OVS

Object–Verb–Subject
Hixkaryana and other rare types

OSV

Object–Subject–Verb
Nadëb, Warao and other rare types

There are 3! = 6 possible permutations of three elements: S, O and V.

Current WALS distribution: counts and percentages

WALS 81A category	Languages	% of 1,376
SOV	564	41.0%
SVO	488	35.5%
VSO	95	6.9%
VOS	25	1.8%
OVS	11	0.8%
OSV	4	0.3%

SOV — Subject–Object–Verb

Example: Japanese: S–O–V; Hindi and Turkish are also commonly described as SOV.



The verb follows both subject and object; the language is therefore verb-final in its basic transitive order.

OV order is strongly associated with SOV.

Postpositions are common (not universal).

Genitive/possessor-before-noun order is common.

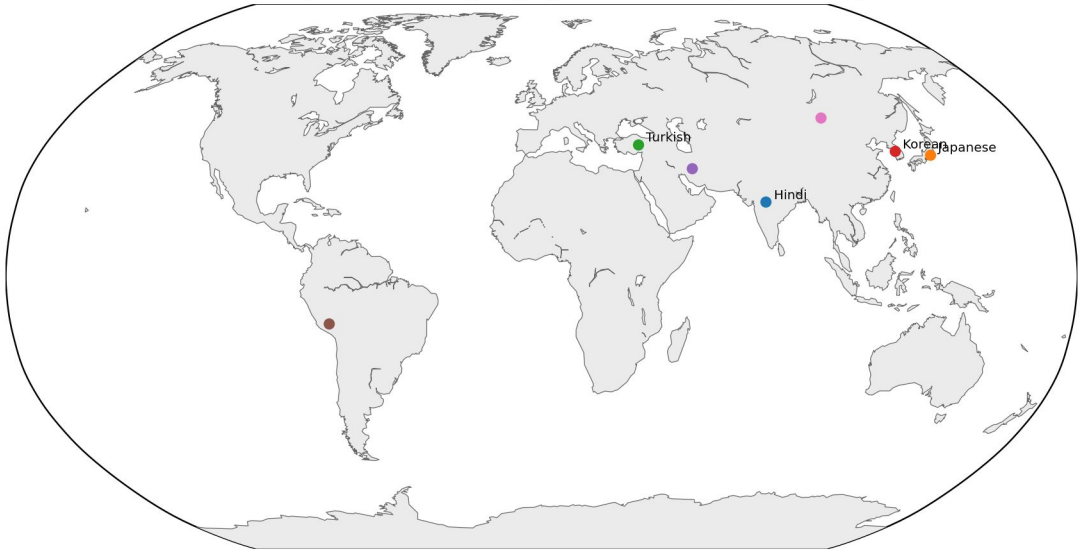
Adverbs often precede the verb.

Auxiliary placement and relative-clause order show strong OV correlations, but individual languages vary.

SOV can coexist with flexible ordering for discourse/pragmatic reasons.

Geographic distribution

SOV: representative geographic locations (schematic)

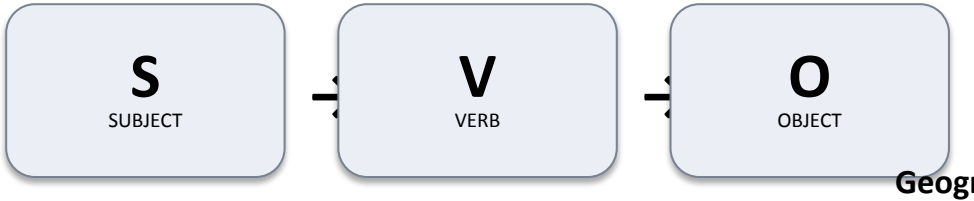


Prominent across much of South/Central/East Asia; also widespread in New Guinea, Australia, and parts of the Americas.

Not a complete WALS language map; use WALS Map 81A for the full sampled distribution.

SVO — Subject–Verb–Object

Example: English: The dog chased the cat. Mandarin also has SVO order.



The verb occurs between subject and object; this is a strongly represented global type.

VO order is characteristic.

Prepositions are common.

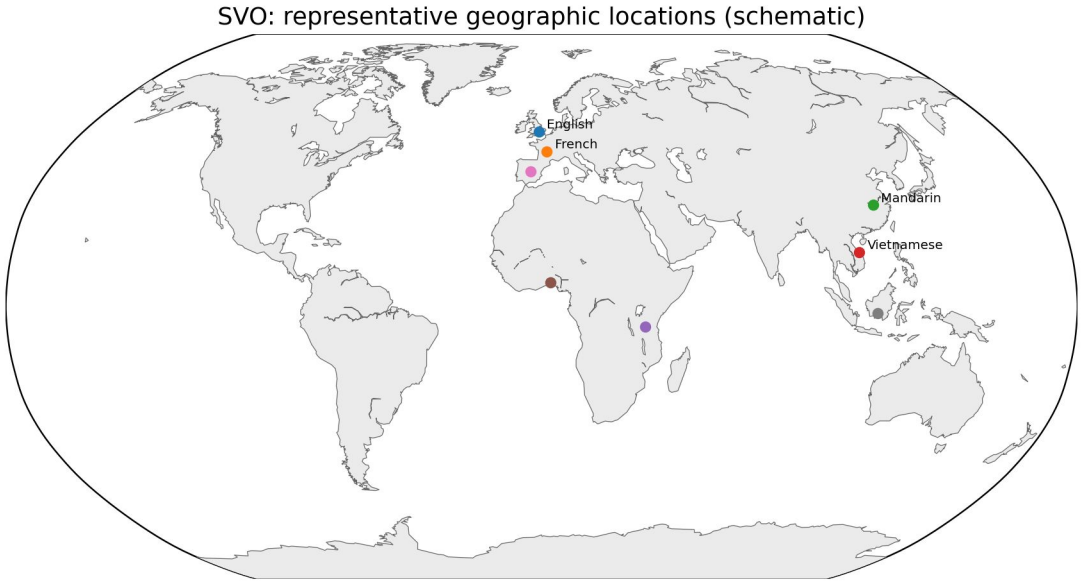
Genitive-after-noun and relative-clause-after-noun patterns are common.

Auxiliaries generally precede the main verb in many SVO languages.

SVO often represents a middle position between strongly OV and strongly verb-initial systems.

Some SVO languages have substantial alternative orders because of information structure or grammar.

Geographic distribution



Common in Europe and around the Mediterranean, much of sub-Saharan Africa, and much of Southeast Asia and the western Pacific.

Not a complete WALS language map; use WALS Map 81A for the full sampled distribution.

VSO — Verb–Subject–Object

Example: Irish: V–S–O. Welsh and Modern Standard Arabic are also commonly classified VSO.



The verb begins the basic transitive clause, followed by subject and object.

VO order: the verb precedes the object.

Prepositions are strongly associated in Greenberg's correlations.

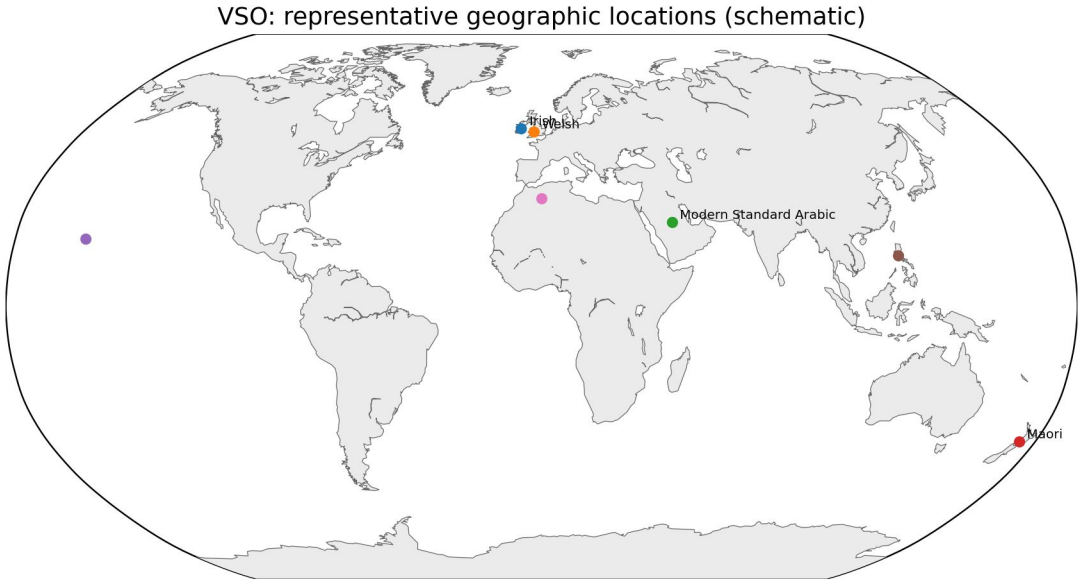
Genitive-after-noun is common.

VSO is far less frequent than SOV/SVO.

SVO is often available as an alternative order; Greenberg Universal 6 explicitly connects dominant VSO with SVO alternatives.

Verb-initial order is geographically scattered rather than concentrated in one continent.

Geographic distribution



Celtic Europe, North/East Africa, Berber/North Africa, parts of the Philippines, Polynesia, Mesoamerica and the Pacific Northwest.

Not a complete WALS language map; use WALS Map 81A for the full sampled distribution.

VOS — Verb–Object–Subject

Example: Nias (Sumatra) is given by WALS as a VOS example; Malagasy is also widely described as VOS.



The verb precedes the object, and the subject follows the object.

VO order is characteristic.

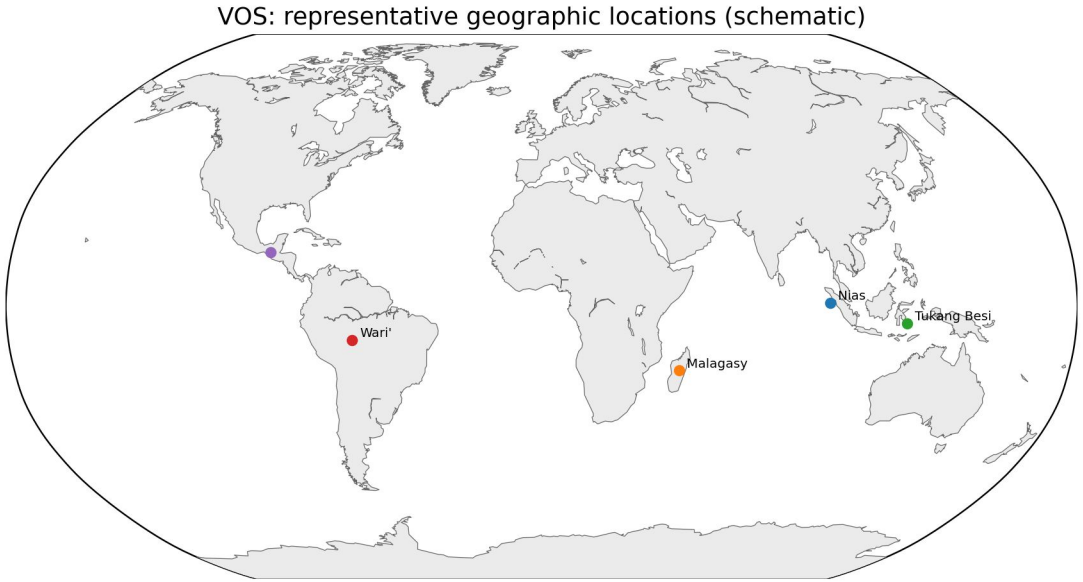
Object immediately follows the verb in the canonical order.

Less frequent globally than SOV/SVO/VSO.

Often occurs in Austronesian and several American language areas.

VOS is not simply 'VSO with the subject moved': the two orders can have different grammatical and discourse properties.

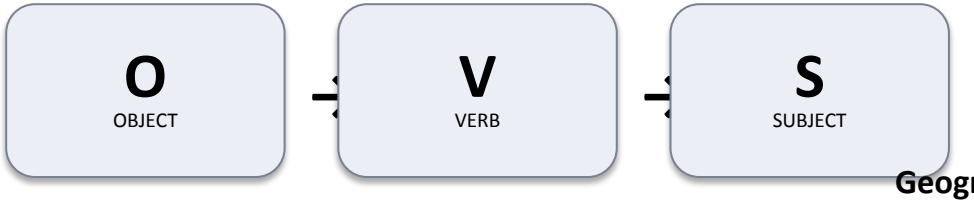
Geographic distribution



Scattered globally; WALS notes no attested VOS instances on the mainland of Africa or Eurasia in its Map 81A sample.

OVS — Object–Verb–Subject

Example: Hixkaryana (Carib; Brazil) is a classic WALS example of O–V–S.



The object precedes the verb, and the subject comes after the verb.

OV order is characteristic.

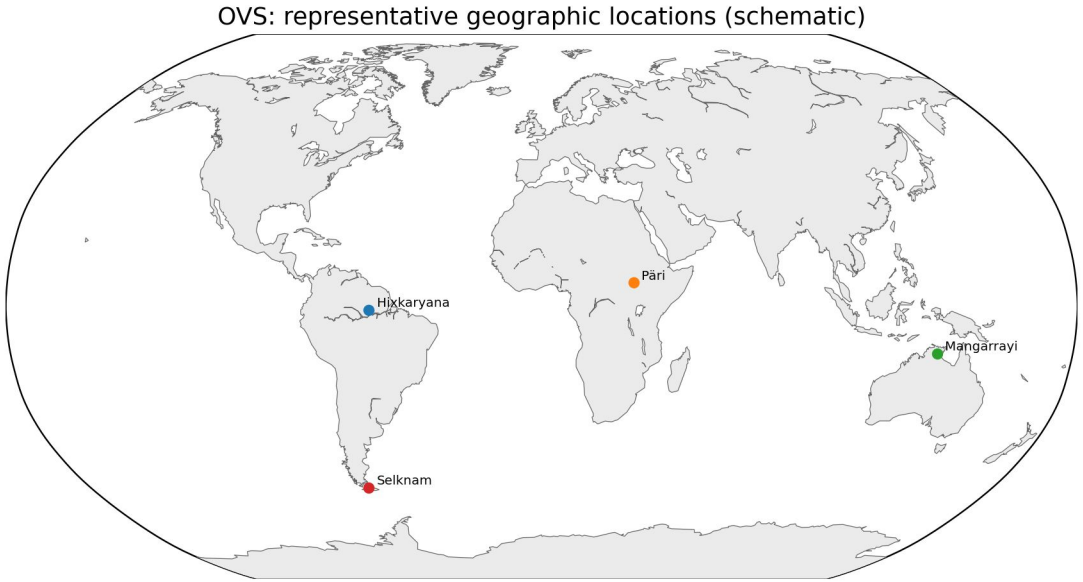
Object-first dominant order is rare.

WALS reports that many OVS languages are in South America, especially the Amazon basin.

The distinction between OVS and flexible OV languages can be methodologically difficult.

Discourse/information structure may permit alternative orders in some languages.

Geographic distribution



Strong concentration in South America in the WALS sample; a small number occur elsewhere.

Not a complete WALS language map; use WALS Map 81A for the full sampled distribution.

OSV — Object–Subject–Verb

Example: Nadëb (Brazil) is a WALS example; Warao, Wik Ngathana and Tobati are among the few OSV languages listed by WALS.



The object comes first, followed by the subject, with the verb in final position.

OV order is characteristic.

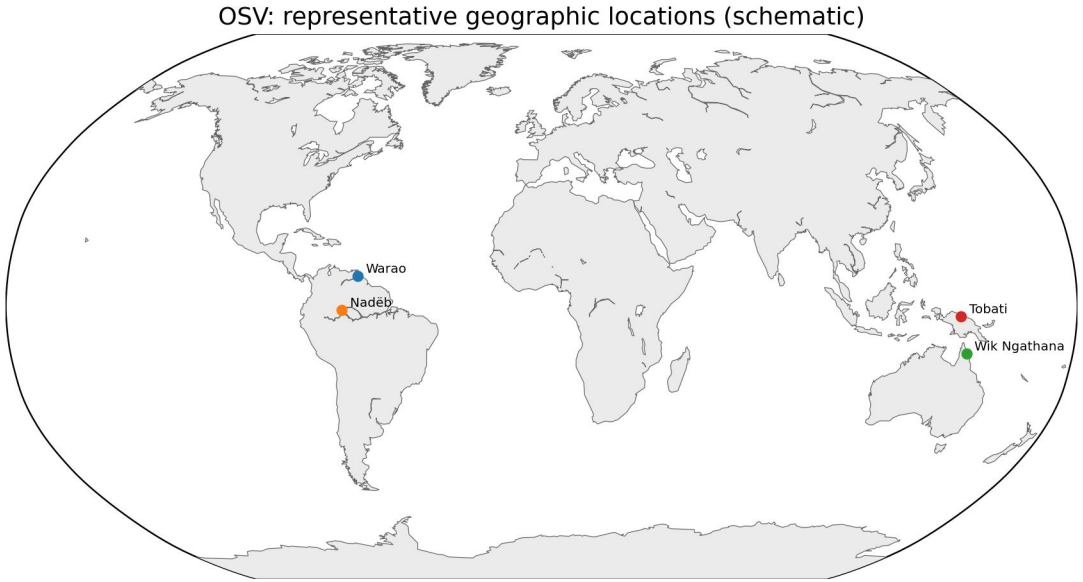
This is the rarest of the six dominant orders in the current WALS 81A table.

Object-first ordering is typologically unusual compared with subject-first systems.

Only a handful of languages in the WALS sample are classified as dominant OSV.

The rarity makes individual-language descriptions especially important; 'free word order' should not be assumed.

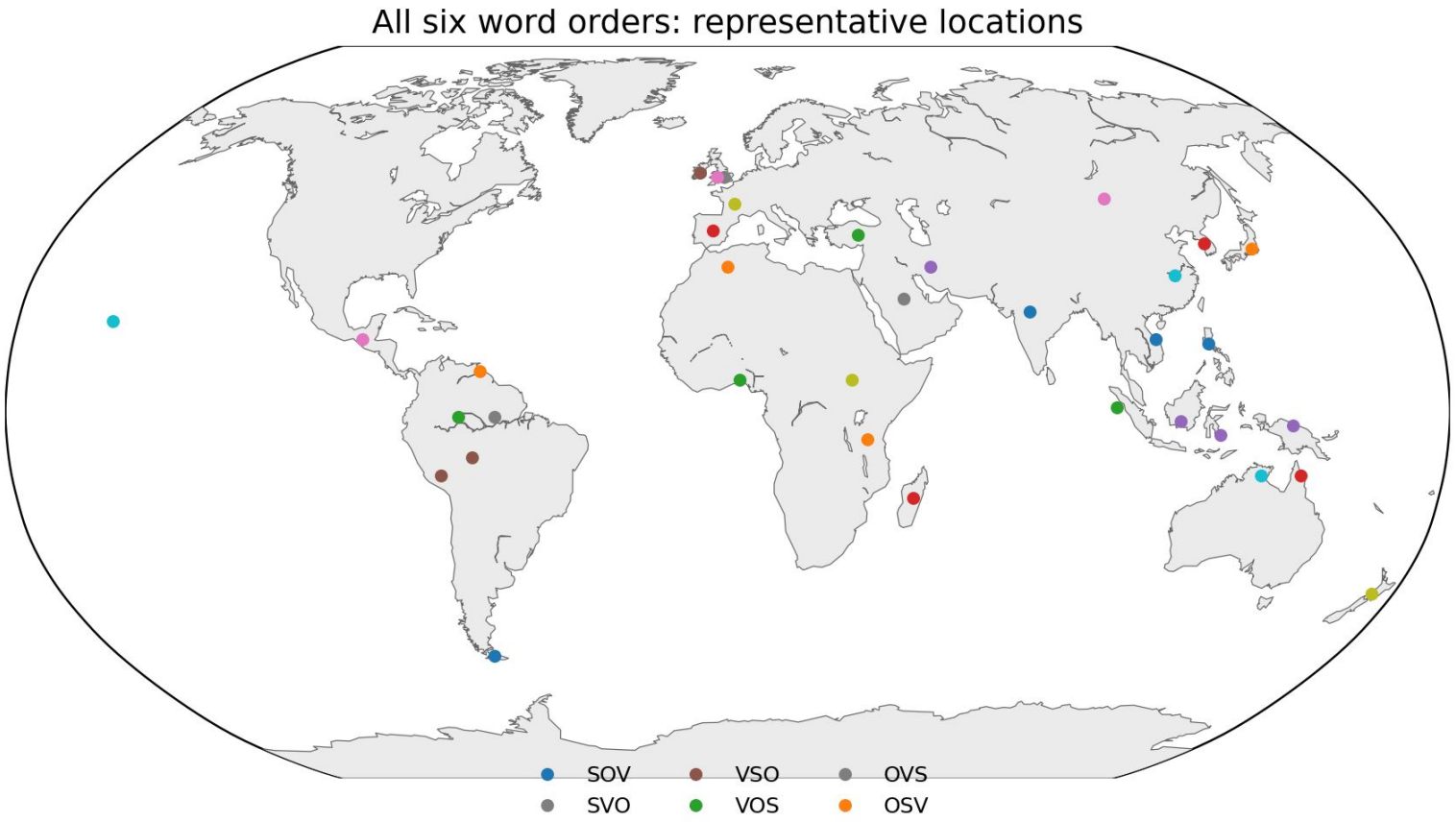
Geographic distribution



WALS identifies only four OSV languages in Map 81A: Warao (Venezuela), Nadëb (Brazil), Wik Ngathana (northeastern Australia), and Tobati (West Papua, Indonesia).

Not a complete WALS language map; use WALS Map 81A for the full sampled distribution.

Global map: all six word orders



Schematic examples only; the exact WALS distribution is on Map 81A.

How to read the map

The points are representative examples, not the full WALS sample.

Use the WALS Map 81A for the complete sampled distribution.

Major patterns:
- SOV: broad global spread
- SVO: Europe/Mediterranean, Africa, SE Asia
- VSO: scattered pockets
- VOS: scattered, especially island/American areas
- OVS/OSV: very rare and geographically concentrated

OPEN WALS MAP 81A →
https://wals.info/chapter/81

Geographic distribution: what the WALS map shows

SOV is the most widespread dominant order and is especially prominent across much of Asia; it is also common in New Guinea, Australia and parts of the Americas.

SVO has major concentrations in Europe/Mediterranean regions, much of sub-Saharan Africa, and China/Southeast Asia into western Pacific/Austronesian areas.

VSO occurs in scattered regions including Celtic Europe, North/East Africa, Berber, the Philippines, Polynesia, Mesoamerica and the Pacific Northwest.

VOS is globally scattered; WALS notes no attested VOS cases on mainland Africa or Eurasia in its Map 81A sample.

OVS is especially concentrated in South America, with many examples in the Amazon basin.

OSV is extremely rare in the WALS sample; WALS lists four languages in Map 81A.

Geography is not destiny: genealogical history, language contact, areal diffusion and independent change all matter.

Greenberg-style correlations: OV/VO and other structures

OV / SOV-LEANING PATTERNS

Often associated statistically with:
- Postpositions
- Genitive/possessor before noun (GN)
- Adverb before verb
- Complementizer at the end of the clause
- Relative clause before noun is common
- Verb-final tendencies

These are tendencies, not definitions of SOV.

VO / VSO-LEANING PATTERNS

Often associated statistically with:
- Prepositions
- Genitive/possessor after noun (NG)
- Adverb after verb is more common
- Complementizer before its clause
- Relative clause after noun is strongly favored
- Verb-initial or verb-medial tendencies

These are tendencies, not definitions of SVO/VSO.

Selected Greenberg universals relevant to word order

Universal 1: In declarative sentences with nominal subject and object, dominant order is almost always one in which the subject precedes the object.

Universal 3: Languages with dominant VSO order are always prepositional (in Greenberg's original formulation/sample).

Universal 4: SOV languages are overwhelmingly more likely than chance to be postpositional.

Universal 6: Languages with dominant VSO order have SVO as an alternative or as the only alternative basic order.

Other universals connect SOV/SVO/VSO with genitive–noun, adjective–noun, adverb–verb and auxiliary placement.

Modern typology treats these as cross-linguistic tendencies with exceptions and methodological qualifications—not as inviolable laws.

Why do the six orders differ in frequency?

Greenberg observed a strong tendency for Subject to precede Object in neutral declarative transitive clauses.

Modern explanations connect word order to processing, discourse/information structure, grammaticalization, dependency length and historical change; no single explanation accounts for every language.

Verb–object adjacency is also common, which helps explain the strong representation of SOV/VO-related systems.

Case marking and agreement can reduce the need for strict positional identification of grammatical roles, allowing more flexibility.

Information structure can motivate marked orders: a language may move an object to the front for topic/focus reasons without changing its basic typological classification.

Typological frequencies should therefore be treated as empirical distributions requiring explanation, not as grammatical 'preferences' in a psychological sense.

Case study: English vs. Hindi

ENGLISH — SVO

The boy read the book.

S → the boy
V → read
O → the book

English relies strongly on constituent position plus other grammatical cues to distinguish subject and object.

Typical associated pattern: VO + prepositions.

HINDI — SOV

The corresponding neutral clause is commonly ordered S–O–V.

S → लड़का / laṛkā
O → किताब / kitāb
V → पढ़ता है / paṛhtā hai

Hindi uses case marking/postpositions as well as word order.

Typical associated pattern: OV + postpositions.

Important: typology compares structural patterns; it does not imply that every sentence in a language must follow one fixed order.

Summary: the typological picture

SOV	SVO	VSO	VOS	OVS	OSV
≈41% most frequent	≈35% second	≈6.9%	≈1.8%	≈0.8%	≈0.3%

Six orders are logically possible, and all six are attested in the modern typological record.

SOV and SVO dominate the current WALS sample; VSO is much less frequent; VOS/OVS/OSV are rare.

Greenberg's lasting contribution is the search for correlations among word order and other grammatical structures.

Word order typology is about dominant patterns, not a claim that every sentence in a language has the same order.

Modern typology combines global mapping with more fine-grained OV/VO, SV/VS, discourse and language-specific analysis.